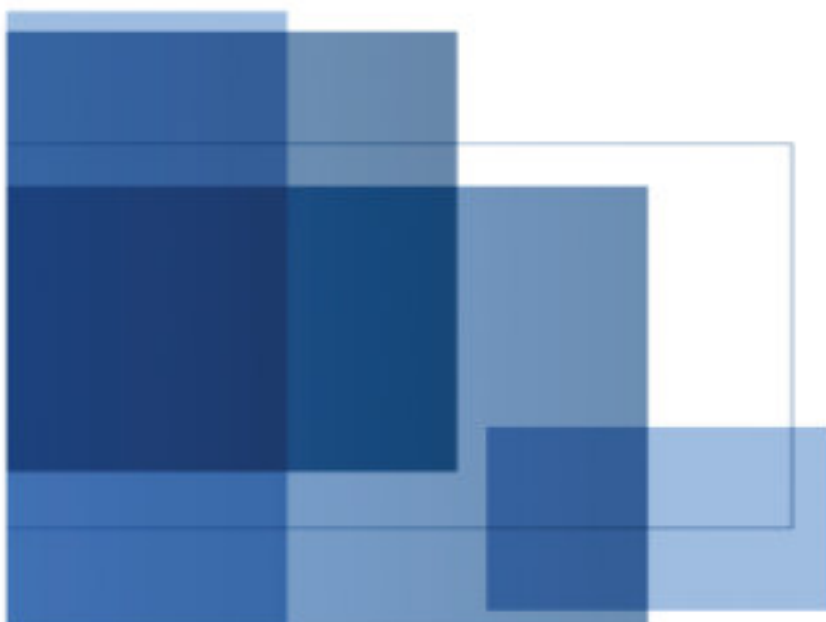




Regional Report

Impact of COVID-19 on sustainability of Civil Society Organizations in the Western Balkans region

March 2021





Regional Report on the impact of Covid-19 on the sustainability of CSOs in the Western Balkans

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Introduction

The aim of this regional report is to depict a picture of the situation of Civil Society Organizations in the Western Balkans during the Covid-19 pandemic. How has the pandemic impacted the sector and in what ways have existing challenges been aggravated by the crisis? Has there, maybe, been a silver lining in the situation where CSOs could benefit, or at least make the best, of it?

Within this broader scheme, the report on hand is particularly concerned with the regional perspective of the Western Balkans. How has regional cooperation been affected by the pandemic? Has the work of CSOs concerned with regional projects been impeded or even stopped entirely, or has maybe the shift towards digital meeting and virtual event planning enabled regional cooperation on a new level?

Most importantly, however, the report will lead towards a set of recommendations aimed at different stakeholders to enable regional cooperation and to strengthen CSOs working in this field, during the pandemic and beyond. These recommendations are based upon desk research conducted for this report as well as a process of consultation with CSOs carried out during a webinar organized online in March 2021.

1. Methodology

The regional report is based upon the analysis of 18 national (case study) reports, looking at the impact of Covid-19 on CSOs within national contexts. Further down in the report, we will present a selected amount of case studies from the Contracting parties (see boxes), but will mostly identify common challenges, opportunities and best practice from the region. Country reports/case study analyses were handed in following an Open Call for Papers by the Western Balkan Fund at the beginning of 2021.¹ There are six reports from Albania, six reports from Kosovo^{*2}, four reports from both Bosnia and Herzegovina and North Macedonia, and one report each on Serbia and Montenegro.

The national reports have been facilitated by institutions or individual researchers. The reports largely analyse the Covid-19 crisis response mechanisms in their respective contracting parties (through desk research and document analysis) to conduct the general climate and challenges for CSOs. The research is in most cases supported by (expert) interviews or the facilitation of focus groups with people working in the sector.

¹ *Western Balkans Fund and Japan Foreign Ministry of Affairs (2021). Open call for research Papers "Impact of covid-19 on sustainability of civil society organizations in the Western Balkan region".* <http://westerbalkansfund.org/2021/01/06/open-call-for-research-papers-impact-of-covid-19-on-sustainability-of-civil-society-organizations-in-the-western-balkan-region/>

^{*2} *This designation is without prejudice to positions on status, and is in line with UNSCR 1244 and the ICJ Opinion on the Kosovo Declaration of Independence.*



There are a few limitations to the data presented in those reports. Some results are based on a very small sample of interview partners. As such, they can surely be read as a valuable insight into individual CSOs or to give one side of the perspective on the situation, presented by people directly concerned. Furthermore, the research with which those reports (and this report ultimately) is concerned looks at very recent (and ongoing) events. As such, not much empiric data has been produced on the issue. Therefore, in drafting this regional report, the national reports must be understood and analysed for what they are: a valuable and important snapshot in time to lay out the foundations for further research, but as well for recommendations and ways forwards.

The limitations of the national reports lead to the limitations of this regional report. In detail, the national reports looked at the national dimension and did not open their case study to the regional dimension. This means that, at the time being, little data on the impact on CSOs in the field of regional cooperation exists. Due to time constraint, it was not possible to conduct follow-up field research (especially interviews) to fill these gaps in the data presented. Moreover, the presented national case studies, and particularly presented data, cannot be validated by follow-up research and as such will be dealt with carefully.

Since the national reports prioritized national perspectives (in line with the wider global trend of re-nationalization in the response to, and analysis of, Covid-19), most of the recommendations in this report are based upon desk research, the authors' own perceptions, as well as lessons learnt from CSO inclusion and regional cooperation before Covid-19 hit, adapted to the new circumstances.

2. Context

Civil society plays a crucial role in monitoring governments, advocating for topics often underrepresented in day-to-day politics or organizing support for marginalized groups within societies. The field of work in which Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) engage is as plentiful as there are CSOs. Oftentimes, CSOs leverage shortcomings of government policies and provide service or advocacy for those groups who fall through the grid of national (or international) policy. All over the world, civil society is charged with similar tasks, however, navigates through very different conditions and environments. This report looks exclusively at the Western Balkans, but within that understanding that the challenges of civil society are often similar around the world, and even more so during the outbreak of the Covid-19 crisis.

In the Western Balkans, different legislations are in place in the respective Contracting countries to enable and support civil society organization, public consultations in legislative processes and participation. On the way towards EU membership, civil society inclusion and empowerment is part of the conditioned democratization process.



It would be nice to say that the mechanism of conditioned enlargement works flawlessly, but many examples throughout the region show that intransparency, nepotism and politicization tendencies have increased again in some of the WB6 over recent years. Covid-19 additionally challenged democratic structures and – throughout the world – was seized as an opportunity by some to justify more restrictive policies beyond the democratically justifiable.

In addition to this, the Covid-19 crisis was used as an excuse by some in the region to focus less, or even undermine the achieved results, on regional cooperation and reconciliation as one of the main drivers for prosperity in the region and one of the main requirements deriving from the EU accession processes of these Contracting Parties. These kind of tendencies and narratives are dangerous in a fragile region such as the Western Balkans which has experienced a lot of human suffering and sacrifices to get where it is positioned now – on a paved, but thorny, way towards the EU.

It would be too easy, though, to blame all recent hardship on Covid-19 alone. In many cases, the pandemic – as unexpected and difficult the situation is – functions as a magnifying glass or a combusive agent. The global market order had long proven unjust, the power structures of the 20th century were challenged, democracy seemed in decline and the rights of the most vulnerable and most marginalized groups were under fire before 2020. The trusted world order was balancing on the edge of the safety board and Covid-19 was the nudge bringing it to collapse.

All of this applies to the Western Balkans as much as it applies to the rest of the world. The social and economic implications of Covid-19 are horrendous, but it is important to analyse the impact of the pandemic within the awareness that the world pre-Covid wasn't all but grand, and especially not for civil society organizations. In its 2019 monitoring report, CIVICUS, a global alliance of CSOs, noted that only three percent of the world's population enjoy life in countries with open civic space and that there would be growing intolerance of dissent worldwide.

Situation of CSOs in the region

The national reports upon which this report builds, acknowledge the poor situation of CSOs before the pandemic in their analysis. Frequently, financial difficulties and a lack of monetary and/ or human capacities made work hard for CSOs before 2020. Despite inclusive legislation and instruments for public inclusion, civil society had struggled with being heard and represented in policy making. Especially organizations working with marginalized communities, such as LGBTIQ

³ CIVICUS (2019) People Under Attack – A Report based on data from the Civicus monitor <https://civicus.contentfiles.net/media/assets/file/GlobalReport2019.pdf>



(ethnic) minorities or domestic violence felt overlooked or purposely ignored in their advocacy efforts. The Regional Cooperation Council in its "Report on the preparation of post-2020 strategy" emphasizes the need to "empower civil society and grassroots initiatives" in order to assist the recovery process from Covid-19 in a situation of "worrying state of democracy [...] scarcity of independent and fully functional institutions."

Civil society is undeniably a crucial aspect of democratic societies, if not the main indicator for the quality of democracy. The EU has recognized the need for strong civil society as a condition for EU membership and regularly assesses WB6 based on civic inclusion in the respective country reports. Governments in the region have reacted in means of legislation (if to varying extends which will not further elaborated in this report), but lag in terms of meaningful participation. Oftentimes, CSOs are engaged in areas where political change has much catching up to do to ensure justice. This concerns for example CSOs working on women rights, LGBTIQ rights or the rights of minority groups, such as Roma. CSOs have here the double task to advocate for basic rights and de-stigmatization and to offer basic care, support or shelter for victims or members of marginalized groups. Being tasked with a great amount of care work within unfavourable environments allows CSOs to often work at a limited scale only, something which explains the focus on local or national activity in the national reports, other than a regional perspective. However, challenges in the WB region overlap. While a local focus in direct care makes sense, advocacy efforts benefit from a regional perspective.

Therefore, different formats are in place to encourage and enable regional cooperation and reconciliation. The EU has shifted largely to a focus on regional cooperation, so have other complementary processes like the Berlin Process. Extensive number of regional institutions, organisations and initiatives such as the Western Balkan Fund, Regional Youth Cooperation Office, Regional Cooperation Council, Central European Free Trade Agreement, Network of Associations of Local Authorities in South Eastern Europe, Regional Rural Development Standing Working Group and many others exist and support these kinds of activities in different policy areas. Civil society has been invited to these formats to unite their powers and assist these entities and others to achieve their regional objectives and take over full ownership. However, this contribution by civil society has been decreased due to numerous challenges they are facing during the pandemic. Advocating and implementing activities on a regional level has become very difficult. People-to-people contact is made almost impossible with the potential to further deteriorate, this will likely put additional pressure on nurturing the culture of regional exchange and mobility. Sustainability, especially financial, in times of crisis has become the priority putting aside the regional connectivity as critical for their own survival.



3. Impact of Covid-19 on regional cooperation and CSOs

Civil society was already organized and working under difficult conditions before the Covid-19 emergency. The pandemic burdened CSOs additionally. They were and are still struggling to mitigate these short-term challenges and figure out on their own, left behind from the state authorities, with the support of the donor community present in the region, to find sustainable solutions for the structural constraints they are facing. Effective and efficient transition of the project activities on digital platforms was prioritised, however, challenges remain also in this area.

Challenges to sustainability, efficiency and outreach

The multiple problems the crisis caused and the effects of various lockdown measures were heavily felt in the CSO sector. Almost all dimensions of work were affected. Three interrelated processes took place: the **disruption of everyday life** gave way to **discontent with the assistance** received by executives but on the other side they found an alternative in discovering options in the online world.

DDD- Disruption, Discontent and Discovery

Disruption

Cancelled projects
Downsizing
New work mode

Discontent

No official economic assistance
Degradation of fundamental freedoms

Discovery

Online options
Resilience and solidarity
Donor flexibility

Shifted work focus

CSOs had to react to the crisis by establishing an emergency support network to leverage the shortcomings of government support. This demanded much from organizations dealing with anyways marginalized groups. The example of CSOs dealing with poor and marginalized communities shows this best. Here, the work focus was shifted entirely, for example to provide face masks and sanitizer to poor communities, instead of the normal advocacy group.



Especially in the early days of the pandemic, many CSOs (temporarily) focused on emergency relief.⁴

The data provided for this report does not include a temporal dimension, hence it is difficult to say in how far the scope of activities has shifted (for good) or returned to a "new normal" over the course of one year.

Changed working procedures

CSO work procedures changed significantly. Not all of them were able to make the online transition quickly and effectively. This process needs investment in technology both as equipment and training although in different scales depending on their previous readiness. The majority of CSOs has very little capacity to meet this demand and faces the challenge of managing this part in a disorganized style. Staff also had to mostly self-train in a relatively short time to acquire the necessary skills and capacities.

Topic: Shifted Work Focus

Interviews and Questionnaires among 108 CSO representatives in Albania highlights the various challenges of CSOs and their employees or volunteers because of the pandemic: "Delays in activities, cancelation of project, losing touch with the beneficiaries in remote areas, lack of calls for new projects, reduced funds and inability to retain staff, decreased motivation for the young staff, donor's delays in decision-making, a lack of transparency, loss of trust in the fairness of awarding projects, big pressure on meeting goals and intensifying activities within a very short period of time, a shift on the pandemic that overshadowed all other needs of the beneficiaries, very frequent, long and time-consuming zoom meetings, lack of long term and impactful projects, etc."

This unique emergency situation could not have been foreseen by anybody, and despite an acknowledgement of donor flexibility the report notes existential financial struggles among half of all CSOs interviewed. Many CSOs found ways to adapt to the pandemic, but without a doubt this adaptation in some sorts often fails to be a satisfying replacement for the analogue work and could only be made at a great human cost. Pressured with the emergency of the crisis a variety of the supporting activities, such as providing "digestible" information, accommodation, food, transport, advocacy, and direct help in isolated areas, were provided by underfunded or unfunded CSOs.

⁴ Balkan Civil Society Development Network (2020): COVID-19: The Effects to and the Impact of Civil Society in the Balkan Region - PART II: The State of CSOs, their Involvement in the Crisis Response & State and Donor Support.

<http://www.balkan-csd.net/novo/wp-content/uploads/2020/05/78-6-Balkan-Civil-Society-in-theCOVID-19-Crisis-Part-II.pdf>



The transition of work to remote or online modes has to be balanced against other developments such as the closure of schools. A laptop or tablet often has to be shared with other family member, work calls and children attending Zoom classes might interfere. The strains on work and family dynamics are well documented throughout these past months as is the increased burden that falls mostly on women.⁶

Think tanks reported a decline in the opportunity to create new networks and maintain existing ones. Networking is a vital process through which experience sharing and new partnerships are enabled and therefore very influential in the academic and policy work of think tanks.⁷

Topic: Work under pandemic circumstances

Networking is extremely important in the 3rd sector for various reasons. Through personal contact, CSOs or Think Tanks can establish relationships with donor organizations and hence secure funds for future projects.

The informal aspects of events allow for the establishment of professional cooperation on a friendly, tentative note. Ideas can grow over a cup of coffee.

A country report by Amalia Koleka (Albanian Institute for International Studies) on Albania quotes a respondent to their interviews: "It is not like anyone thinks this is an ideal situation. I have never logged into a conference and heard the panellists say 'It's great to see you in this format!'. Everybody says 'Hopefully next year we will be able to see each other in person.' Theoretically we are closer and more connected, but practically we are very far apart and isolated".

Last but not least, the lack of analogue contact and networking also adds to the emotional burden of the pandemic. At this point, all reports note the exhaust of employees. The absence of informal gatherings or exchange adds to the impression that work has become harder during the pandemic. This is not limited to those working in CSOs or think tanks.⁸

⁶ United Nations Women, (2020). The COVID-19 pandemic has increased the care burden, but by how much?

<https://data.unwomen.org/features/covid-19-pandemic-has-increased-care-burden-how-much-0>

⁷ Albanian Council on Foreign Relations, (2021). "Impact of COVID-19 on sustainability of Civil Society Organizations in Albania".

⁸ Albanian Institute for International Studies, (2021). The impact of Covid-19 pandemic on Networking: challenges and opportunities for think tanks.



Regional cooperation is a specific field where the limitations of networking and especially the disappearance of people to people contact put on hold and in some cases reversed some hardattained achievements. The previous enormous work being done by civil society often with the help of regional mechanisms that fostered peacebuilding, regional understanding and youth friendship and partnerships were severely affected as now there were no more interactive events with required presence and therefore no opportunities to network directly in formal and informal settings.

Regional cooperation is and will remain to be limited in scope and actions in the months to come following the publication of this Report, despite occasional periods of relaxation. During this crisis period, the work of civil society organisations, especially on regional level, is severely diminished not only for the lack of international travel and state-imposed travel restrictions and quarantine, but also because of layoffs in the sector and insolvencies. This could seriously undermine the results which have been achieved in previous years, especially in the field of reconciliation.

Service providers bear the brunt

The CSOs working at grassroots level provide valuable services to sectors of society that are most in need or that face specific and sensitive problems. During the Covid-19 crisis they were hit hard by the limited access to their direct beneficiaries. Their initial sacrifice of providing direct assistance (economic and PPE) was a testament to their commitment and integrity.

CSOs providing services and communicating with segments of society which belonged to the lower socio-economic strata and in marginalized areas face the biggest difficulties.

Furthermore, limitations over in person meetings and travel meant that they were **no longer able to reach their beneficiaries** especially those in rural, marginalized areas and those in socio-economic need which had little or no access to technological means of communication. This distance only grew over time, and later translated into hard earned trust and partnerships being lost. Efficiency and outreach took a hard hit during the harsher months of the pandemic. Even for organizations that were able to revitalize their networks online, a **significant drop in the quality of engagement** is reported.



The organizations that work with vulnerable group such as people with disabilities, children ⁸, victims of domestic violence ⁹, minorities ¹⁰, LGBT rights and others in addition to facing all the spectrum of general difficulties had extra risks to mitigate as their work affects the lives of the target groups much more directly and in the short immediate term.

One relative advantage is that the difficulty of the situation put the service-providers at the limelight again and their performance raised awareness about the need to have more support for the organization that work directly with communities

Topic: Vulnerable Groups

In Kosovo*, CSOs working with ethnic minorities worked in extremely challenging conditions before the pandemic. As Dhurata Prokshi observed in her country study, CSOs bemoan the fact that the communities' hardship is systematically ignored by politicians. The vulnerability of ethnic minorities – Roma, Ashkali and Egyptian – in Kosovo* became obvious early on into the pandemic. As representatives of CSOs reported, many families lacked basic access to hygiene facilities such as running water.

From the beginning of the pandemic, measures such as mandatory mask wearing financially pressured members of poor communities. This means that CSOs were challenged with the task of immediate emergency response. On the flip side this means that capacities for political advocacy are even more limited than under normal circumstances.

Prokshi's analysis highlights that the difficult situation in which CSOs act during the pandemic is not caused by Covid-19. Instead, the lack of inclusion of ethnic minorities in policy making, the insufficient funding and donor structures, as well as the structural discrimination towards these groups challenged CSOs before 2020. The pandemic has only made the existing struggle worse.

⁸ Kelmendi D. & Vagarri K. (2021) "Impact of COVID-19 on the sustainability of Civil Society Organizations, in child rights sector in Kosovo"

⁹ Bozo A. & Vora E. (2021) "Impact of COVID-19 on sustainability of Civil Society Organizations in the Western Balkan region"

¹⁰ Prokshi Dh. (2021) "Impact of COVID-19 on sustainability of Civil Society Organizations in the Western Balkan region"



The two Janus heads of technology:

The pandemic moved much of the world's life from the physical to the virtual sphere and the Western Balkans are no exception. While digitalization offers great opportunities and could potentially lower the threshold to access events, it only works its charm if available to everyone.

Unfortunately, "Nearly half of all households in the six Western Balkan economies lack computer access at home. Additionally, about one third lack fixed broadband internet connections, which offer higher, more reliable connection speeds than other types of broadband connections," confirms a 2020 OECD report on the region¹¹.

For the status quo, the digital requirements of working, schooling and living at home often require improvisation or mean exclusion of or further discrimination against vulnerable groups or poorer, marginalized communities.

Technology's nature as both a blessing and a curse has been a topic overexposed and analysed to detail during the months of the pandemic. In the case of the relationship of CSOs with their ICT tools that enabled them to do most of the work, especially during the tough lockdown months, this two-faced nature is riddled with questions. Most CSOs are more than grateful for the existence of online tools. The transfer of activities to the online realm was for many the key strategy to guarantee survival and some of them even to thrive.

However, the benefits are tangible for those with satisfactory access to the internet and, as important, with some level of digital literacy. Older generations, as well as people in rural areas and underprivileged socio-economic standing have very little of both. Therefore, the digital divide plays a big role in dividing beneficiaries from those left behind in the larger frame of adaptation.

Looking at regional project, the organization of webinars and panel discussions online has many benefits. Organizations working, for example, on topics of European integration have noticed a much higher attendance in their (online) events than ever before in physical meetings. Having online events that require no travel and therefore no disruption of previous set of agendas means that CSOs could attract selected high-profile contributors or speakers to their events.

¹¹ Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development, (2020). The Covid-19 crisis in the Western Balkans - Economic impact, policy responses, and short-term sustainable solutions. <https://www.oecd.org/south-east-europe/COVID-19-Crisis-Response-Western-Balkans.pdf>



However, also in the sphere of regional cooperation and European integration, solely digital work has its limitations. Many Think Tanks had been able in the recent years to break the ice and to form initial partnerships and contacts with their peers in EU member states. These partnerships had begun to translate into new, different and better narratives about the Western Balkan region. These new perspectives, largely built upon physical meeting, exchange and networking, are particularly valuable in EU member states that remain sceptical about enlargement. With the onset and perseverance of harsh travel and meeting limitations this relationship was thrown again into a long-distance affair.

Topic: Vulnerable Groups

In Kosovo*, much of the care sector shut down in March 2020 as a response to the pandemic and some remain closed into 2021. This concerns especially day care centres or family services. At the same time, the government introduced an NGO funding scheme which, however, was limited to two months (March and April 2020). For their analysis, Klevis Vagari and Donjeta Kelmendi interviewed representatives in the child/ family care sector. Respondents unify on the perception that their work has not only gotten harder because of financial hardship and less capacities among workers and volunteers. Especially in the work with vulnerable groups and troubled families, NGOs are focused on emergency response, consequently side-lining prevention programmes or follow up services.

Before the pandemic, the complete lack or underrepresentation of childcare services including but not limited to foster families, centers for children with disabilities or rehabilitation and reintegration services challenged the work of NGOs in this sector. With the restrictions in mobility, more children fall through these supportive structures in times which are particularly challenging for children.

Furthermore, the sector depends largely on human interaction and direct contact for support and prevention. This is largely impossible during the pandemic. Hence, the sector suffers from a lack of resources and funding persistent before the pandemic. Additionally, lockdowns and isolation demand now a level of adaptation from NGOs which is hard to unite with their traditional approach.

Personal impact

On a personal level, lockdowns, work from home and forced isolation challenged those working for CSOs. Individuals experienced private hardship which cannot be underestimated in the evaluation the crisis. In interviews, employees of CSOs lamented to be overworked and lacking motivation.



The **increase in the mental health problems** related to isolation that ensued remote and online work is also well documented². As the pandemic progresses there is a parallel increase in frustration with long online meetings with very little interactivity and an impossibility to verify participation.

Topic: Vulnerable Groups

Within the scope of the open call, no report focused on the impact of Covid-19 on individual security. However, in all countries, NGOs working with vulnerable groups reported an increase in domestic violence, mostly of women and children.

This trend has been observed throughout the world and is conditioned by many different factors. CSOs from the region report increased need for psychological support, social services and online legal services.

At the same time, isolation keeps victims of domestic violence locked up at home, making it more difficult for them to reach out for help. Since schools or family care facilities are closed, service providers are less able to notice the signs of abuse in children or women. The isolation puts them in danger. Often, trust is hard to gain through online service or, in absence of safe space at home, it is impossible for women or children to reach out for help.

Financial hardship

As mentioned before, CSOs are a vital part of a democracy. In the Western Balkans (as is the case elsewhere) CSOs rarely are entirely self-financed. Besides membership or event fees, they rely on financial support through funds, donations, or individual donors. Many CSOs have reported positively on the flexibility of donor organizations who expanded deadlines for already approved funds or a last-minute change in project proposals (such as, transforming events to an online format). At the same time, the support received from governments has been assessed as rather poor. In the case of Kosovo*, for example, CSOs were considered within the first emergency package. Financial support was however only granted for two months, even as the pandemic continues to prevail after one year. The financial insecurity of the crisis burdens every sector, however CSOs, as a sector traditionally underfunded, struggle even more.

²Giorgi, G., Lecca, L. I., Alessio, F., Finstad, G. L., Bondanini, G., Lulli, L. G., ... Mucci, N. (2020). Covid-19 related mental health effects in the workplace: A narrative review. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 17(21), 7857. doi:10.3390/ijerph17217857; See also McGrath, P. (2021). Nearly 60% say mental health hit BY Pandemic - CSO. <https://www.rte.ie/news/coronavirus/2021/0225/1199322covid-mental-health-ireland/>



The global nature of this crisis meant that **the donor Contracting Parties on which many of the CSOs depend were affected simultaneously** and themselves had to adapt to the situation. In some cases, this meant cancellation of projects, downsizing of existing projects or suspension of activities. Sustainability became the priority issue as many CSOs were forced to let staff go and in some cases close shop.

*Fundamental freedoms deteriorate*¹³

The pandemic found a regional context already ripe with authoritarian tendencies, limited media freedom and overall brittle democracy in all the member Contracting Parties.¹⁴

When it comes to Covid-19's impact of Civil Society one must first acknowledge the obvious dilemma of the health crisis. As consequence to the quickly, by means of Aerosols, spreading virus, the public space was locked down as a first response to the crisis and has been narrowed ever since.

Mobility, hence transregional public space, has been restricted even more to avoid a quicker spreading of the virus.

While distancing is stringently required as a response to the pandemic, it also bears the danger to silencing the public. Especially in times of crisis, the contribution, monitoring and advocacy of CSOs is needed more than ever. At the same time, the nature of the health crisis demands to restrict public space. In spring, governments had rigorously banned (and fined) public gatherings including public protest. Alternatives to act or to be heard have not necessarily been offered¹⁵. The dilemma of a state's responsibility to both protect its citizens from the virus and from breaches of their fundamental freedom has been prevalent throughout the crisis. Only with transparent measures and public involvement in decision-making at least to a certain extend would be needed to operate the narrow path of protection and repression. The research for this report shows that public consultation has been absent or extremely narrow during the entire pandemic.

¹³Todorovic, S. BIRN (2020). Civil society filled a void in the Balkan pandemic. <https://balkaninsight.com/2020/10/13/civil-society-has-found-its-voice-in-the-balkan-pandemic/>

¹⁴European Western Balkans, (2021). Freedom House: Western Balkans saw both setbacks and progress.

https://europeanwesternbalkans.com/2021/03/03/freedom-house-western-balkans-saw-both-setbacks-and-progress/?fbclid=IwAR1tmuyoAopsN-VLbs8brQ80NDf7HPP9j64ohwTzP9xL62A6clpQ_RhLhywo

¹⁵ To compare, please see: Balkan Civil Society Development Network (2020). COVID-19 Pandemic: The Effects to and the Impact of Civil Society in the Balkan Region Restrictions on Civic Space and Citizens' Basic Freedom. <http://www.balkancsd.net/novo/wp-content/uploads/2020/04/78-5-Balkan-Civil-Society-in-the-COVID-19Crisis.pdf>



The public health crisis hence provided legitimacy to a set of measures taken by various governments to protect public health. However, this opportunity was in some case misused to go beyond the necessary measures and limit fundamental freedoms, or even worse provide grounds for human rights' infringements such as the disclosure of identity of infected people⁸ or changes in Penal Code that would impose unjust extreme punishments.¹⁷ The measures were sometimes faced with scepticism and even lack of compliance which resulted in social frictions and polarization. Additionally, other institutions that would serve in the past as stabilizing forces retreated from public life almost entirely. Courts were generally closed and legislative assemblies acted as mere notaries of executive. This new context made the work of the civil society sector even more difficult as they had to **balance their advocacy for compliance with health measures with doubling down on their monitoring role of democratic practices and human rights.**

Nonetheless, CSOs stood their ground as watchdogs for fundamental freedoms and reacted in real time to do their part in protecting them. Often partnering with the office of the respective Ombudsman or various media platforms they reached out to the public and to European institutions (such as The European Court of Human Rights)⁸ to denounce measures or initiatives that they analysed as unnecessary violations of basic civil liberties.

Given the increasing authoritarian trends in the region and the deteriorating conditions for media freedoms¹⁹ this part of the work of CSO is set to remain substantially hard and require more support and external assistance both in political and financial terms. The pandemic and other forms of emergencies are skilfully used by executives all over to justify increasing intervention space. In the long term the civil society sector will increase its monitoring and reaction reflexes to counteract and counterbalance this type of political usage.

⁸ Balkan Civil Society Development Network (2020). COVID-19: The Effects to and the Impact of Civil Society in the Balkan Region – PART I: Restrictions on Civic Space and Citizens' Basic Freedoms.

http://www.balkanncsd.net/novo/wp-content/uploads/2020/04/78-5-Balkan-Civil-Society-in-the-COVID-19Crisis_300420.pdf

¹⁷ Think for Europe Network, (2020). The Western Balkans and Covid-19 effects on good governance, rule of law and civil society. <http://www.legalpoliticalstudies.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/07/The-Western-Balkans-andthe-COVID-19-Effects-on-good-governance-rule-of-law-and-civil-society.pdf>

¹⁹ Balkan Civil Society Development Network (2020). COVID-19: The Effects to and the Impact of Civil Society in the Balkan Region – PART I: Restrictions on Civic Space and Citizens' Basic Freedoms.

http://www.balkanncsd.net/novo/wp-content/uploads/2020/04/78-5-Balkan-Civil-Society-in-the-COVID-19Crisis_300420.pdf

¹⁸ European Western Balkans, (2021). Freedom House: Western Balkans saw both setbacks and progress. https://europeanwesternbalkans.com/2021/03/03/freedom-house-western-balkans-saw-both-setbacks-and-progress/?fbclid=IwAR1tmuyoAaosN-VLbs8brQ80NDf7HPP9j64ohwTzP9xL62A6clpQ_RhLhywo



Topic: Freedom & democracy

CSOs in Albania notice a worrying degree of the disrespect of human and civic rights by the government. The pandemic would be used, as presented in several country reports, to silence civil society especially those working on questions of democracy and human rights. Decision-making processes on measures to react to the pandemic have been centralized to the Prime Minister's Office. This means that civil society is completely excluded from consultations. The legislative process has been criticized as being not transparent. Information remains difficult to access, making life harder for CSOs working on democracy and human rights in the country.

Because of the secretive attitude of the government, CSOs remain charged with the task to monitor the government closely and to provide (accurate) information on the state of the pandemic, as well as the measures by the government.

The role of CSOs for informing and education the citizens is highlighted in several country reports on Albania. That said, capacities need to be made available for CSOs to provide this kind of "service". This would include, besides financial stability, investment in the staff (including skill trainings and workshops) as well as strengthening of civil society networks for a cooperative approach. Across reports, the need for cooperation and solidarity to mitigate meaningful legislative change (not limited to democracy and human rights)²⁰ pops up as a lesson-learned from the pandemic.

4. Measures taken by the CSOs and lessons learned

Despite the unprecedented crisis and operational challenges, the majority of the CSOs have demonstrated incredible resilience, quickly moving to new ways of communication and remote (online) work. Fortunately, the majority of the CSOs across the region were not forced to close or significantly reduce their activities. Some of them even set positive examples.

The youth organization Epoka e Re from Albania launched the initiative #DoGoodFromHome. By using digital tools, the organization sent positive messages to the local community to empower young people in a period of crisis. Under the slogan: "Physical Distancing is not Social Distancing for us... Let's get together" online activities were organized to engage young people in delivering messages on the importance of social inclusion during the COVID-19. #OnlineDebateClub started using web-conferencing platforms, where young participants shared ideas on different topics concerning the communities they live in. With the COVID19 Extraordinary Call the CEI-Executive Secretariat has enabled the Albanian NGO Help the Life Association (Ndihmoni Jeten) to implement the project "Disability E-learning Platform (DEP)"

²⁰ Balkan Civil Society Development Network, (2021). *Balkan Civic Practices: Civil Society in the Covid-19 Pandemic*. <http://bcp.balkancsd.net/>.



By firstly setting up an online platform developed by a specialized IT company, they started the e-learning process in October 2020. Research for best practices and similar models were prepared by the main expert. Hence, they identified two main categories of beneficiaries who needed to be supported: the ones with an autism spectrum disorder and the ones with intellectual disability. Each category has its own formats divided by age group; these two categories represent the most common diagnoses the organisation works with. In total, 34 children, youngsters with disabilities and their families have received online services from 4 specialists, twice a week. Overall, 270 one-hour sessions have been provided. Moreover, the staff is still working on new programmes for additional beneficiaries who will be introduced to the platform to reach the beneficiary number set in the project.²¹

In Bosnia and Herzegovina, the EU-funded Regional Program for Local Democracy in the Western Balkans (ReLOaD), implemented by UNDP alongside 21 local communities and CSOs, identified the areas in need. More than 50,000 people will benefit from the CSOs' work on the procurement of protective equipment for the most vulnerable categories of people, providing psychosocial support, and animation of the youngest and oldest citizens.²²

In North Macedonia, ad hoc grants, provided by the Civica Mobilitas programme and implemented by the Macedonian Centre for International Cooperation (MCIC) intended for overcoming the extraordinary situation caused by COVID-19 enabled a rapid response for CSOs' target groups. For example, One Can, Romalitico, and HOPS, worked on mapping needs, coordination and distribution of humanitarian aid to single parent families, Roma families, people who use drugs, sex workers, children who use drugs and their families. The organization Interactive and Wake Up have implemented activities for access of the young and other citizens of support via digital tools, etc. Some of the donors also opened ad-hoc grant for crises such as the Swiss Embassy and EU Delegation in Skopje. Emergency Intervention grants were distributed to 5 CSOs through the Civil Society Resource Centre, and Civica Mobilitas awarded 10 CSOs with ad-hoc grants to deal with the Covid-19 pandemic. Also, the Foundation for Open Society Macedonia, in cooperation with the Macedonian Red Cross, donated 100.000 USD for humanitarian support, including food and hygienic packages for the Roma population.²³

²¹ Central European Initiative: Forum of best practices for Civil Society Organisations and Local Authorities cooperation <https://www.cei.int/events/forum-of-best-practices-for-civil-society-organisations-and-local-authorities-cooperation-forum-of>

²² Balkan Civil Society Development Network, (2021). Balkan Civic Practices: Civil Society in the Covid-19 Pandemic. <http://bcp.balkanncsd.net/>

²³ Balkan Civil Society Development Network, (2021). Balkan Civic Practices: Civil Society in the Covid-19 Pandemic. <http://bcp.balkanncsd.net/>



The Swiss Agency, through the ACT project, has decided to provide additional funds to 3 organizations that will be supported in helping vulnerable groups in Serbia. Open calls for proposals from diverse donors have been launched, such as the UNDP call for innovation in crisis time; Central European Initiative – Emergency Call for Proposals for COVID-19 2020. Moreover, Trag Foundation created a program to support the solidarity among the citizens by relying on their capacities, considering the safety and health in the community. It is expected the implemented actions to reduce the further spread of the virus, to help the most vulnerable, and to launch operations focused on the recovery and resilience of communities from the economic and other social consequences. The Foundation Ana i Vlade Divac announced a specific call for associations, media, and grassroots organizations gathered around a joint idea to help citizens in facing the crisis.²⁴

5. Donor and government response in support to CSO sector

The practice of state funding of CSOs in the Western Balkans is rare, and where existent, limited and underdeveloped. Therefore, the CSO sector is very much, if not entirely, dependent on donor support in the region. This degree of dependency sometimes translates into donor-driven agendas of projects and interventions. However, on the positive side, the assistance of donors frees the sector from government or private influence under conditions when such influence can be detrimental to fragile democracies. The donor community's assistance was crucial for civil society's sustainability during the pandemic as well. Besides financial assistance, donors prioritized health at work and guided CSOs on how to operate in a state of crisis.²⁵

The EU is arguably the region's biggest donor. Apart from the first-hand COVID-19 assistance, the Union committed to supporting the socio-economic convergence and recovery of the Western Balkans in the long run by boosting its competitiveness, human and entrepreneurial capacity in the fields of research, innovation, health, education, culture, youth, and sport, providing full economic participation for all its citizens, including the Roma.²⁶ One of the key principles of the EU's Economic and Investment Plan is fairness and inclusiveness. This results in the European Commission's pledge to foster the implementation of the European Pillar of Social Rights (EPSR) in the region and increases IPA funding in the areas of education and skills, employment, and social protection and inclusion, youth, health, culture, and sport. In that sense, the bloc envisions support for greater involvement of the civil society and the private sector, promoting innovative solutions and social entrepreneurship.

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ Ibid.

²⁶ European Commission, PRESS CORNER (2020). Western Balkans: An Economic and Investment Plan to support the economic recovery and convergence. https://ec.europa.eu/commission/-/presscorner/detail/en/IP_20_1811



Moreover, the Erasmus+ programme will be enhanced with opportunities for academic mobility and capacity building, including the vocational education and training sector. The needs of the youth are a special priority for the EU, given the high unemployment. Hence, the Union promotes the Youth Guarantee mechanism based on the example of EU Youth Guarantee, aimed at providing young people with a smooth transition from school to work and to support labour market integration.²⁷

As for relevant donors' responses to the pandemic, the majority of CSOs seem to be happy and grateful about the level of flexibility and understanding that they have received during these difficult times. However, the continuance of business as usual when it comes to burdensome reporting requirements or the lack of new calls for proposals is highlighted by a part of the sector as well.

Preserving and enriching this degree of flexible and needs-based assistance as well as introducing simpler (often shorter) administrative requirements for application and reporting is something that has the potential to assist CSOs work well beyond the pandemic.

The assistance needed from the donor community seems to be multifaceted and goes beyond financials. CSOs are right to believe that the crisis represents an opportunity to bring more vitality and flexibility to the grant making process and even more fairness in the evaluation process. CSOs which are involved in providing service for vulnerable or marginalized communities point out that the crisis laid bare the needs of the communities they look after. Therefore, they must be prioritized.

On the other hand, when one casts an overall look to the region it is easy to observe that **the CSO sector was not a priority to governments when they designed and distributed economic assistance**, subsidies, or any other form of aid. The fact that only in North Macedonia and Serbia civil society organizations were either recognized as beneficiaries of economic support measures or were eligible to participate in calls for financial support to cope with the COVID19 crisis yet without significant funds allocated is more than telling about this (mal)practice.²⁸ What is more, funds initially allocated for civil society organizations have been reallocated for other means in non-transparent procedures, while the sector was either entirely excluded from the crisis-management consultations and decision-making or included without substantial say.^{29,30}

²⁷ European Council/Council of the European Union, (2021). Youth Employment/Youth Guarantee. <https://www.consilium.europa.eu/en/policies/youth-employment/youth-guarantee/>

²⁸ Ibid.

²⁹ Ibid.

³⁰ Think for Europe Network, (2020). The Western Balkans and Covid-19 effects on good governance, rule of law and civil society. <http://www.legalpoliticalstudies.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/07/The-Western-Balkans-andthe-COVID-19-Effects-on-good-governance-rule-of-law-and-civil-society.pdf>



Also, governments throughout the region did not welcome the intervention of CSOs when they duly required more respect for fundamental rights³⁰ or an inclusive and transparent approach to the distribution of assistance. The relation between the third sector and the governments in the region started from a strained point nevertheless. The pandemic just exacerbated previous dynamics of distrust, and the lack of substantive cooperation.

Furthermore, the relation between CSOs and media is also a challenge for governments. CSOs in collaboration with independent media were in some cases successful to start investigations over matters related to the pandemic and purchase of medical equipment.³¹ The government's legitimating narrative on the other hand informed official sources where, on the flip side, civil society's intervention where sometimes presented as harmful to the public health protection. Expectedly, this distorted representation was an immediate concern and additional burden for activist CSOs or informal groups of civic activists. This was certainly the narrative deployed behind the banning of condemning public protests even if they occurred respecting measures and distances.

Overall, CSOs who are not well-established actors lacked and lack appropriate institutional support from the donor's community or the states, and so do CSOs whose primary activities include providing support and care for the marginalized groups, such as LGBTIQ+ support centres, shelters for victims of domestic violence, organizations involved in providing institutional support for persons with disabilities. Furthermore, printed media fell victim to the pandemic and was forced to entirely cease operations or substantially reduce their activities.³² We single out some negative examples: In Kosovo, the Covid-19 pandemic harmed four renowned newspapers, causing an existential financial crisis, due to businesses suspending their marketing campaigns. Consequently, currently, there are no printed newspapers available in Kosovo.³³ In Albania, Help the Life Association³⁴ asserted there is a need for national authorities to review their social priorities in light of the COVID-19 crisis, redressing the focus on persons with disabilities and their services at the heart of the recovery.³⁵ In North Macedonia, the CSO "PORAKA" highlighted that the pandemic has dramatically put on hold long sought reforms as that on deinstitutionalisation with the concrete risk to discard all positive results achieved so far.³⁶

³⁰ Avdiu Germiza A., (2021). Impact of COVID-19 on sustainability of Civil Society Organizations in the Western Balkan region: The Impact of Covid-19 Pandemic on the Printed Media; See also: Balkan Civil Society Development Network, (2021). Balkan Civic Practices: Civil Society in the Covid-19 Pandemic. <http://bcp.balkancsd.net/>

³¹ Ibid.

³² European Association of Service Providers for Persons with Disabilities: Stronger cooperation is needed to support Western Balkans and Eastern Partnership support services <https://www.easped.eu/en/content/stronger-cooperation-need-ed-support-western-balkans-and-easternpartnership-support-services>

^{33,35} Ibid.



6. Conclusion and recommendations

The crisis is still unfolding and with the insecurity of vaccine supplies in the region it is unclear if (and when) a time of definite normality can be expected on the horizon. In the meantime, **the civil society sector has shown incredible resilience** despite having thrown multiple challenges on its way.

It is of utmost importance that the lessons learnt are not lost and that **the current challenges serve as reflection points for the sector** and its supporters and stakeholders.

The reflection process can then lead **to necessary restructuring of the activities of CSOs** by prioritizing the subsectors most in need, **by resetting and enhancing regional cooperation** and by **improving the interaction between this sector and the donors' community**. The agenda of cooperation can be redesigned in light of the items that the pandemic has brought to the limelight but also become more aligned with the Contracting Parties', and the region's, development and integration.

This report depicts a picture of the situation in the civil society sector in the Western Balkans during the Covid-19 pandemic. The impact of the pandemic to the sector was substantial and joint efforts in order to preserve sustainability are needed by all actors involved. The pandemic strongly aggravated already existing sustainability challenges that the CSOs were faced with already before. The analysis has shown that the CSOs are facing many other challenges that directly influence their work on national level. The situation is even more complex on conducting operation and activities on regional level. However, the report shows along best practises on the ground how each of the actors involved (civil society organisations themselves, governments and regional organisations and mechanisms and finally the donor community), can adapt to the current circumstances in order to come out stronger together.

RRR: Resilience, Reflection, Restructuring vitalization

Resilience:

flexibility, creativity
and adaptation skills

Reflection:

comprehensive crisis
preparation processes

Restructuring:

new strategic alliances
and better aligned
agendas



Recommendation for CSO and think tank sector: Never let a crisis go to waste

This experience taught the civil sector the hard way that **every organization, even if it is nonfor-profit, can benefit from a crisis strategy or protocol and undergo specific crisis management training** in order to develop basic skills for future similar scenarios³⁶. Just as successful business have risk mitigation options, the civil sector might need to use the reflections gathered during these testing times to design plans for themselves on how to face unexpected major upheavals. CSOs have now gained a solid rationale to start a dialogue with their most trusted donors for the need to establish such strategies or contingency plans and even reserves³⁷ which can be deployed in times of dire need just as those that the pandemic had in store for all of us. However, in order to move forward to such a future-oriented planning, CSOs need an environment in which their everyday activities are supported, not challenged.

That said the crisis strategies and protocols **should be tailored to reflect the characteristics of the sector which differs from business**, usually the recipients of these types of documents. The starting point is the recognition that CSOs are generally small in size and without accumulated financial reserves that will provide them with the necessary long-term sustainability. Flexibility and adaptability in its operations remains a challenge.

A consistent and smart approach towards investing in digitalisation and training the staff on how to use digital tools is very much needed. The transition of at least part of the work and public engagement of CSOs online is here to stay even when the Covid-19 crisis finishes. Therefore, the ICT assets and skills should be gradually strengthened, and be part of CSOs long term strategic plans.

Investment in shared approaches and cooperation will benefit every sub-sector of civil society. The pandemic has shown how important cooperation and solidarity are for successful ways forwards during the crisis. This spirit of solidarity is key to success also in situations without dire emergency. Even though it might seem counter-intuitive during times of distancing and isolation, CSOs are well-advised to build strong networks throughout the regions for the way forward and stronger positions now and in the future.

Recommendations for state authorities and regional institutions, organisation and initiatives

The crisis reveals the necessity for different stakeholders to work together and coordinate assistance. This is a new setting that can serve as an important reflection and turning point in this relationship for mutual benefit.

³⁶ Gjoni E., (2021) We've survived the Covid-19 crisis. How far can we go in "survival mood" CSOs voice on how to make their work more direct and sustainable

³⁷ Korançe F., for Build Green Group Albania (2021) "Open call for research Papers "impact of covid-19 on sustainability of civil society organizations in the WESTERN Balkan region"



Governments should recognize the civil society and media, especially those at high risk of extinction such as marginalized groups' support centers and shelters, as employers and contributors to the society and include them in the direct and indirect financial aid packages, providing substantial economic support for their daily operations. The CSO sector is a small but significant barrier to the massive brain drain phenomenon that affects the region, becoming often a hub for excellence and retaining people educated abroad. This added value deserves recognition by governments in their approach to brain gain initiatives.

The CSO sector also has accumulated experience and expertise that can provide immense help to government and public administrations if there is a mutual trust and an environment of collaboration. **All sides need to evaluate mechanisms for communication and collaboration and upgrade or modify them accordingly.** Parallel to facing this crisis all the countries in the region are also trying with a lot of difficulty to progress in their EU integration path. **The assistance of the civil society sector and organisations that work and promote regional cooperation in this regard can prove essential.** The Contracting Parties will move forward if the entire region progresses on this path.

The digital agenda for the region³⁸ is a unique comprehensive opportunity that needs to reflect the lessons learned and needs identified during the pandemic. The region will be assisted in this aspect by the European Union which has identified it as a priority in its Economic and Investment Plan for the Western Balkans.³⁹ The civil society sector needs to be identified and supported as a direct beneficiary of this transformation.

Recommendation for the donor community

The donor community should continue to demonstrate flexibility and understanding for CSO work, especially for those at high risk of closure, including tailor-made approaches of crisis funding to ensure that their operations proceed uninterrupted. At the same time, donors should refrain from complicated and bureaucratic reporting procedures, which will ease the unnecessary burden to CSOs' work during pandemic times. While it is true that the majority of CSOs adapted to the crisis situation and 'survived' the first year of the pandemic with novel means of communication and remote working, it is also true that most of them, even the well-established, mentioned that they will not be able to continue with their operations meaningfully if the pandemic lasts for a longer period of time.

³⁸ Regional Cooperation Council (RCC), 2020. Majlinda Bregu: Common regional market is the way forward. <https://www.rcc.int/news/650/>

³⁹ European Union and European Commission (2020). Economic and Investment Plan for Western Balkans, Flagship initiative Nr. 8. <https://ec.europa.eu/neighbourhood-enlargement/sites/default/files/factsheeteconomic-and-investment-plan-2020.pdf>



Regional cooperation and associated delicate and complex processes such as reconciliation are at risk. Hard fought achievements are being slowly undone given the difficulties in people-to-people contacts and the lack of networking opportunities. Donors and regional funding mechanisms should partner up, recognize this specific challenge and respond by designing supportive initiatives to revitalize regional networks and actions.

The risks inherent in extremely limited direct contact should be mitigated with smart tools that go beyond the usage of online communication platforms.

The need for institutional (organizational) grants, supporting the work of CSOs, that go beyond specific topics and limited timelines is laid bare by the difficulties presented during this pandemic. CSOs need to be able to build up resilience towards crisis, something which cannot be done by project grants. Therefore, **institutional building support that translated into direct investment in staff and equipment as well as skills and development grants that upgrade digital capabilities are essential.** This requires a more strategic involvement of donors in planning and categorizing their funds in direct communication with CSOs.

Finally, **donors who have farmed current support as exclusively dealing with the Covid-19 pandemic should consider expanding their portfolio of topics** given that long term priorities and strategic fields of intervention such as regional cooperation, reconciliation and peacebuilding, rule of law, enhancing public services and freedom of expression that are still crucial to this region and need to be in the forefront of the supporting agendas.

WBF and the Report's co-authors are aware of the complexity of the situation we are passing through, of many elements and specifics that maybe are not included, or fully covered, or extensively explained in the Report. Therefore, along with our hope that you will find the document useful and inspiring, in order to make it better and more inclusive, we would like to receive your suggestions and comments at: info@westernbalkansfund.org.

Thank you!



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